

Perm fails to take seriously the notion that all reformist politics are predicated on the social death at the heart of the prison-industrial complex. We must draw clear demarcations against the PIC.

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Whether it is social death by incarceration, political death by neutralization and disenfranchisement, productive death by exploitation, or physical death by execution, capital and its state-form predicate the life of the wealthy, the white, and the privileged on the death of the poor, the black and brown, and the impoverished. No reformation of the current system will lead to this total transformation. Reformist movements fail to recognize that social and physical death are essential to the functioning of the present social system. Consequently, reformist movements refuse to acknowledge that destructive actions are necessary in the struggle for liberation. We must concentrate on the structures and institutions that we need to destroy just as much as we focus on the practices and formations we must construct to be free. We must eliminate enforced social death entirely for us to be able to constitute alternative social organizations that truly provide for democratic freedom. In addition, we must hold this systemic transformation in mind as we engage in our various local struggles. For, without this total vision - what Rodriguez calls an abolitionist "political fantasy" - our local successes will be doomed to mere reform.

Uncompromising abolitionist struggles are the only way to win transformative victories over

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wrenched out of the system of racial capitalism that founded America. That fight is already occurring, it's being led by the prisoners, and the pressure they exert is essential to the advance of any policy

change or non-reformist reforms promoted by the article. It is incredibly disappointing to see the scholar-activist abolitionists who wrote this article distance themselves from prison rebellions, prisoner solidarity organizations, and the roots of the abolition movement. One of these authors, Dan Berger has made his career studying political prisoners and black liberation revolutionaries. He wrote *The Struggle Within* and *Captive Nation*, which draw from the rebellions of the 1970s. In this article he departs from the respect and honoring of black revolutionary intellectuals that characterize his other works. He's erased the fact that prison abolition was largely founded on George and Jonathan Jackson's deaths and their willingness to die rather than be incarcerated a single day longer. It is an egregious offense for this scholar of that history to now say "a fever-dream demand to destroy all prisons tomorrow... [is] highly idiosyncratic and unrepresentative... [of] abolitionist organizing." Why is this happening? Why is Berger betraying his inspiring research subjects for Jacobin and Lancaster? What reason do these abolitionists have for reframing and excluding radicals and revolutionaries from abolitionism? It appears they'd like to convince Jacobin's readers that most abolitionists are respectable people whose vision is not so far from Lancaster's. They also seem keen to define abolition in a way that academics can comfortably adopt without risking career advancement. Then there's the suspicious coincidence that they've limited abolition's tactical scope to approaches that center the work of the non-profit industrial complex and pandering politicians. We don't like speculating about the potentially self-serving motives of our allies. We'd rather trust that Berger, Kaba and Stein focused their article on what they saw as the most tedious aspect of Lancaster's tired argument. We trust, but not blindly. The last paragraph of *What Abolitionists Do* recognizes the "urgent need for robust debate" and claims that the "debate must engage what exists in on-the-ground organizing". We agree, which is why we believe the discussion must include prison rebels and the organizations that fight with them. Anarchist Black Cross Chapters, The Incarcerated Workers Organizing Committee of the IWW, and various other groups are working to back up the prisoners who refuse to be slaves today, who won't wait for some imagined non-reformist reformed future. We and the prisoners we work with have coordinated the largest prison strikes and protests in history. According to estimates from Solidarity Research, our actions can cost prison systems hundreds of thousands of dollars per day. One anarchist prison rebel in Ohio did the math and concluded that a well supported prisoner strike would tank not only the prison system, but the entire state budget in a few weeks' time. On August 18, when Lancaster's article came out, prison rebels and their supporters had frightened Florida and South Carolina into locking down their entire system for the weekend, costing them thousands of dollars, and significant public support. We are building power and pursuing abolition by making prison impossible, not merely by slowly reforming it out of existence. Abolition now! is not just for "bumper stickers or social media" it is a call to action which is being answered, which is accumulating power, and which can mutually reinforce the work done on non-reformist reforms. and all the oppressive systems that depend upon it, but not if the non-reformist reformers are more interested in appealing to Lancaster's disciplinary vision than in solidarity with prisoner resistance.